

6. Fresh is best (for you and for the environment)

Environment: Food processing can add further pressure on the environment. The more complex the processing, the higher amount of energy and materials required, which leads to higher CO₂-eq emissions and resource consumption per kilogram of product (Notarnicola et al. 2017). For example, the CF of fresh peas can increase by 60% to more than 100% when purchased canned, jarred or frozen (Clune et al. 2017, Carbon Footprint Frozen Food Report 2012). The global warming potential (GWP) of processed tomatoes (chopped, peeled, puréed) can be twice the amount of fresh tomatoes due to the energy use for processing and packaging (Del Borghi et al. 2014).

Health: The increasing proportion of ultra-processed foods in diets has been identified as a driver of excess energy intake (Monteiro, 2010). Also, the evidence thus far shows that displacement of minimally processed foods and freshly prepared dishes and meals by ultra-processed products is associated with unhealthy dietary nutrient profiles. (Monteiro, Cannon et al. 2018).

7. Drink tap water rather than bottled water whenever possible and safe

Environment: When safe tap water is available, the use of water in plastic bottles places an unnecessary burden on the planet. An analysis of 6 different Italian water providers showed that consumers can save on a yearly basis 163.50 kg of CO₂-eq per capita by drinking 2 litres of tap water rather than PET-bottle water (Botto et al. 2011). In terms of water savings, bottling 1.5L of water requires around 1.9 extra litres of water for bottling operations, processes, packaging and transport (Nicolucci et al. 2011), compared with 0.5 litres of extra water if using tap water responsibly from efficient municipal systems. Bottled water in plastic material poses a further environmental burden, as plastic production relies heavily on oil (Foolmaun & Ramjeawon 2008), and in the EU the amount of plastic recycled in many countries is still less than 50% of the production (Plastic Europe 2017).

Health: Good hydration is vital for good health and well-being. Water safety and quality are fundamental to human development and well-being, and 71% of the global population uses a safely managed drinking-water service (WHO, 2017). The reason for the increase of bottled water consumption is not straightforward; one of the most common factors seems to be consumer dissatisfaction with tap water organoleptics, i.e. the water characteristics that affect the senses of taste, odour and sight (Miguel, 2006). However, the quality of bottled water is not necessarily superior when compared with municipal tap water, as shown by Rosa et al. (2011) in a study conducted on 37 bottled waters available on the market and 15 municipal water pipelines.